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Anthropomorphism in *Professional Crocodile* and Agamben's 'man-animal'

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ABSTRACT
Anthropomorphism and animality are central themes in children's literature. This article offers an original engagement with them, via the picture book *Professional Crocodile* (2017) by Zoboli, Giovanna, and Mariachiara Di Giorgio, and Giorgio Agamben's *The Open: Man and Animal* (2002). The picture book offers a particularly nuanced and ironic take on the difficulty of maintaining a human/animal divide: even at the simplest level, Mr. Crocodile is an animal living as a human whose job involves pretending to be an animal. Through a detailed analysis of the constitutive perspectives of this text, further ironies are drawn out, leading to a questioning not only of wider constructions of animality, but also professionalism. Agamben's man-animal enables a reading of the antagonisms of division, but also, through the internal dash ('-'), the necessary excess such antagonisms call upon.

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1. Introduction: animals, identity, and children's literature

This article is concerned with a subject that has received considerable critical attention: the animal, and the animal/human hybrid, but especially in so far as it is framed within children's literature, and children's literature scholarship.[1] In engaging the subject, I am interested in problematising what one dominant approach to it within framing accounts is arguably, as articulated, for example, in the following from Carolyn L. Burke and Joby G. Copenhaver:

> Most children are curious about and fond of animals. Many of us share our homes and our hearts with our pets. […] So, it would seem rather intuitive that these creatures would find a place in the stories that we tell. And they do. But when these animals begin to talk and scheme and learn to read, we have gone past their intuitive inclusion in a repetition of reality and have put them to use in a purposeful distortion of reality. This use of

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> anthropomorphism prompted the question: Why do animals with human characteristics populate so many early childhood stories? What purpose do they serve?[2]

Here, although Burke and Copenhaver are interested in the differences between people and animals, they are equally engaged with those instances when a clear distinction between the two appears to be challenged. The difficulty I read with their notion of 'animals with human characteristics', however, is that, in this context, animals remain as such, even 'with' characteristics that may appear to contradict them. Certain types of characteristics ('human') can be owned, and the strength of this possession persists even when these traits are shared 'with' others. For Burke and Copenhaver, we are thus not defined by our characteristics, and our identity is resilient against excess. The consequences of this perspective can be further explored in the context of 'anthropomorphism'.[3] If, within children's literature criticism, anthropomorphism is generally called upon to question the divide between animal and human, as Sue Walsh suggests, within a body of work that has had a significant influence on this present article, this is often achieved through an 'equivocal questioning of materiality', with the problematisation of the divide between animal and human reinstating the difference.[4] For an additional example of the kind of thinking Walsh argues against, we might refer to Helen Adhuze's recent definition of anthropomorphism within children's literature as 'the imposition of human traits on nonhuman objects and animals'.[5] I read Adhuze to claim that 'traits' are imposed, thus implying that the animal is known before such actions take place – an inherent creature whose existence or characteristics are completely distinct and intrinsic to it. The difficulty Adhuze is encountering here is one that has been discussed extensively in Animal Studies scholarship: to what extent is it possible to engage the animal outside of human frameworks?[6] With this in mind, we can return to Burke and Copenhaver, as they can be viewed as naturalising reality in a somewhat different way by emphasising its repetition and distortion. In their formulations, certain types of literature may seem to repeat reality, indicating that textuality does not always establish a distinction. Such an understanding requires a concept of a shared reality, one that can be distorted by what is being written about, rather than by writing itself. It is not only that animals exist primarily for humans in Burke and Copenhaver's formulations (with the hierarchy implied by this, as well as the capitalist context, remains unrecognised.), but that literary representation repeats this understanding. The clear, shared, non-textual reality upon which Burke and Copenhaver ground their analysis is, for them, so compelling that any departure from it is taken to be deliberate, viewed as 'a purposeful distortion of reality'. Therefore, I would argue that this perspective leads to a pragmatic or functional interpretation

of literature. Deviation requires purpose, purpose requires an end, and the recovery of that end is taken to be the point of literature criticism.

In order to draw out the problem of both 'animals with human characteristics', and a notion of the use or instrumentalism of animals within literary criticism, I will offer an extended close reading of a text that I take to engage such issues with particular nuance: Giovanna Zoboli and Mariachara Di Giorgio's *Professional Crocodile*.[7] Originally published as *Professione Coccodrillo*, the work has been translated into several languages from Italian,[8] including the English translated book, *Professional Crocodile*. As the publisher, Topippitorri, provides both Italian and English explanations about their books on their website, and particularly promotes the English version, and as this is an English language article, it is to this version that I will turn my attention in what follows.[9]

2. 'Mr. Crocodile' is 'he', not I

Zoboli and Di Giorgio children's picture book concerns 'Mr. Crocodile', whom we see waking up, getting ready, and travelling to his job. As I believe much of the book's appeal comes from the delayed revelation of the reality of his working environment, I have designed this article for those unfamiliar with the book in a way that replicates its structure, insofar as the readings within it lead to the revelation without explaining the twist from the beginning. I do hope that in so doing some of the strength of the narrative (and my own enjoyment of it) can be conveyed more effectively. With that in mind, let us begin at the start of the text.

The first sentence is 'Mr. Crocodile loves his job'.[10] The crocodile in *Professional Crocodile* is thus identified as a working male. What is more, as a *Professional Crocodile*, he is not merely employed, but also an expert at something and works within specific rules of conduct. However, the title and the illustration on the front cover do not manifest what kind job he has. Based on provided information, the illustrations in this book, therefore, are presenting the idea of the professionality of Mr. Crocodile *no matter what he does for his living*. My interest here lies in the boundaries of occupation. What does a job consist of? What excesses might professionalism call upon?

Here, Mr. Crocodile is visually and verbally narrated from a perspective other than his own. The perspective is always *on* the crocodile. He is viewed and regarded as the one who loves his job and his role as a professional employee. Even before we get to questions of hybridity of species, that is, to the question of the otherness of identity (whether that be of an 'animal with human characteristics', or an alternative formulation which might question the ease with which animal can be differentiated from human), there is another otherness in play: the other of narration, without which Mr. Crocodile would not be constituted as such. Indeed,

although Mr. Crocodile is written as 'Mr. Crocodile' and commented on as 'he loves his job', he does not say anything in any frames in *Professional Crocodile*. Counter to Hegelian traditions, the animal does not oppose speech or language, to the extent that there is no language *spoken* in this world.

As indicated above, the illustrations after the front cover show the process of Mr. Crocodile waking up dreaming and preparing to go to work. On the next page of the title page, the first frame shows the crocodile lying on the bed. I see a pillow and a pair of slippers. Mr. Crocodile is wearing pyjamas, and the eyes are blindfolded with a black sleeping mask (see Figure 1). Above him, there are four black circles and an additional frame, which is a smaller frame that also features an illustration of a crocodile. Thus, the larger frame contains Mr. Crocodile along with another smaller frame containing an illustration of a crocodile (Figure 1). If I consider the first frame as depicting Mr. Crocodile sleeping until 7 am in the morning, to what does the smaller black frame refer? If the black frame shows a dream of Mr. Crocodile, then that dream can be seen by someone other than Mr. Crocodile. The dream in this case is situated outside the dreamer, whilst also including an individual similar to the dreamer. Are we reading here a repetition of crocodiles or a single crocodile repeated? The crocodiles in each frame are depicted in different environments. Inside the black frame (or the dream), for example, the crocodile is not on the bed, is not wearing anything, and is floating on the dark water (Figure 1).

To explore the complexities of identity and framing here, we might turn to the front cover, which, as we shall read, has a rather intricate design, including a further, repeated and 'hidden' image of a crocodile, that can further

Figure 1. Mr. Crocodile at 7 am.

problematise the narrative of the dream. However, we have much to address before we reach that point, so let me instead focus on the scenes that immediately follow the dream, where Mr. Crocodile is preparing to leave for work.

Mr. Crocodile was alone in the initial frame, but on the following page, the exterior view of his house shows that different creatures live together under the same roof. Based on this scene, I can observe that there is no strict barrier of dwelling between animals and human beings (see Figure 2). The first frame on the left side shows the scenery of Mr. Crocodile's house at 7 am Since it is framed within a rectangle surrounded by a white border, the complete view of his residence is not visible in this frame. From the exterior of his house, particularly in the first-left frame, I can see windows and part of some trees. Some windows are open while others are closed. Mr. Crocodile is brushing his teeth, and a girl is brushing her hair in another window below (Figure 2). If the creatures in this world are not required to engage in simultaneous actions, similar behaviours emerge, such as having open windows in their rooms or using bathrooms, this regardless of the animal identity of those involved. Furthermore, while the creatures inhabit the same house, the interiors do not necessarily resemble one another (Figure 2). Consequently, Mr. Crocodile resides in a world that does not necessarily oppose individuality.

Mr. Crocodile awakens at 7 o'clock in the morning, and four birds are seen flying outside his residence (Figure 2). I find it intriguing that he is positioned *inside* the house while the birds are *outside*, without wearing any clothes. The birds in the first frame occupy a different space to Mr. Crocodile. Furthermore, Mr. Crocodile and the birds differ not only due to their distinct classifications – being a reptile compared to the avian nature of the others – but also in their respective contexts and environments. Is this difference attributed to the clothing that Mr. Crocodile is wearing? Is this difference inferred from the illustration because Mr. Crocodile, like the girl, is dressed while the birds are not? Do they appear different because Mr. Crocodile is a *professional* crocodile, whereas the birds are not identified as such?

Figure 2. Mr. Crocodile is preparing to go to work.

What would happen to Mr. Crocodile if he were to go somewhere without wearing his clothing?

But here a pause: how is a notion of wearing to be read in this book? If wearing is to be read here, I would suggest, it is through Mr. Crocodile's preparations (Figure 2): he chooses his tie and then, he adjusts his hat. There, the act of wearing extends beyond the event. If wearing is dependent on a prior preparation of dress, Mr. Crocodile's professionalism is likewise dependent on the process of preparation. The professionalism of Mr. Crocodile does not stem from the *internal* space of his workplace. For example, Mr. Crocodile is not at work when he chooses his tie. However, the act of changing or wearing some clothes contributes to his image or identity as a Professional Crocodile. Here we might reintroduce the girl: because I see her only once in this book and do not see any of her preparatory processes, she not only contrasts with Mr. Crocodile regarding the significance of intentionally wearing clothes, but she can also be interpreted in relation to the birds, which, although they are outside and unclothed, appear only in a single frame. Thus, the clothing, which should secure the human, or human characteristics, also, in one scene, problematise the security of the opposition, requiring Mr. Crocodile to be singled out for opposition.

Further issues of identity arise in terms of the different images of Mr. Crocodile preparing, as sequence or continuity is confirmed through the repetition of frames. Because Mr. Crocodile appears in every frame, we understand that a continuous narrative is being offered. However, this also necessitates that Mr. Crocodile is duplicated, with each instance separated from the next by the frame. Indeed, the frame is essential for securing the sequence and establishing the continuity of identity, while also serving to distinctly separate each image, disconnecting it from its surroundings. In this way, Mr. Crocodile is shaped by a perspective that is other to his identity, with the frame itself functioning as such an excess.

3. Mirror and 'animal-man'/ 'man-animal'

What I am reading here is a problematisation of identity: the divisions or combinations of animal and human that can be read here hinge on a frame that does not seemingly exist in either. How might this notion of a constituted excess necessary to the identities of both animal and human be read? Let us turn to the work of a contemporary Italian philosopher with a long-standing interest in the relationship between humans and animals, Giorgio Agamben. Agamben has raised the case of 'an animalization of man (an animal-man […])' and 'a humanization of the animal (a man-ape)' to problematise the clear boundary between animals and human beings in his book, *The Open: Man and Animal*.[11] However, what Agamben ultimately argues in his book is that the man and animals are in

different categories. We are thus talking about a non-relation between the two.[12] The first example can be found from the subtitle: 'Man *and* Animal' (my emphasis on 'and'). 'Man' and '[a]nimal' are recognised differently although they are something to be addressed together. Agamben not only suggests that there is a difference 'between' 'man' and 'animal' later in his book, but also that there is *something* which 'distinguishes man from animal'.[13]

To think this through, let me bring in one further formulation from *The Open: Man and Animal*: '[t]he animal-man and the man-animal are two sides of a fracture, which cannot be mended from either side'.[14] Counter to the understanding of Burke and Copenhaver, 'The animal-man' here is not an animal, and 'the man-animal' is not a man. In the cases of '[t]he animal-man' and 'the man-animal', they are already 'side[d]' as such. They are divided into 'two' different 'sides'. Although '[t]he animal-man' is related to the 'animal', '[t]he animal-man' is sided as 'man' (in that sense, 'the man-animal' is sided as 'animal'). '[A] single fracture' has been claimed with 'the two sides'. Whether '[t]he animal-man' or 'the man-animal', 'the fracture' is one. Does the 'fracture' refer to a dash between 'animal' and 'man'? Or to the ambiguity between man and animal of '[t]he animal-man' and 'the man-animal'? Whichever way these fall, 'a single fracture' mending is not possible for 'the two sides of' it, both '[t]he animal-man' and 'the man-animal'. Due to the impossibility of 'mend[ing]', I read the unchangeableness from 'the man-animal' and '[t]he animal-man'. In my reading, Agamben is not suggesting this leads to a collapse into meaninglessness; rather, something is slipping away here due to a lack of correspondence. There exists a difference that cannot be transcended or easily synthesised into 'hybridity' or the concept of 'with[ness]' in attributes. As we will examine in the penultimate section of this essay, the human cannot touch the animal without reverting to oppositional thinking (such as the distinction between being and beings) in which it does not participate. Conversely, the animal cannot touch the human because it exists outside the structure that defines it.

Here I would return to the problem of the fracture or the dash, the third that is neither animal nor man, but repeats across animal-man and man-animal. The concept of oppositional thinking could be further complicated if we consider the fracture, which is distinct from animal-man or man-animal – and consequently also the dash – by examining its singularity, even though both terms represent different sides of it. However, being sides of a fracture, in one sense, stages the fracture's disappearance. The fracture consists solely of these two sides; there is no fracture apart from its components. In other words, the concept of fracture introduces a sense of lost wholeness. Neither the fracture nor wholeness can exist in isolation; both require the framework of difference. This framework itself may lead to a

collapse: both sides of the fracture are indeed both *sides*. There is a sameness to the difference. What I am analysing here does not negate the absolute difference I have observed between man-animal and animal-man, highlighting their sense of being incomparable and not existing within the same frame. However, there are nuances that accompany this absolute difference, creating further essential divisions. It is to this complexity that I will now turn, in a reading of an image we have already encountered: Mr. Crocodile in the mirror, choosing his tie.

If Mr. Crocodile can be regarded as 'the man-animal' or 'the animal-man', to borrow the terms from Agamben's text, the division that establishes and maintains this identity can, however, be questioned through additional distinctions and further repetitions. Let us return to the second-left frame from Figure 2 and read it as it also appears on the front cover. The crocodile, wearing a dotted shirt with suspender and striped pants, is looking at the mirror (see Figure 3). I mention 'mirror' because there is another crocodile within the brown squared frame. In so far as there is a mirror, these two crocodiles can be recognised as the same and also not the same, because the one is a reflection of the other (and not the same also, in so far as this image is subsequently repeated in the text).

In my reading of the mirror, there is something illogical about these two crocodiles; the two crocodiles are holding different ties on their left arms – The crocodile in the mirror is holding a dark purple one below his neck and the red striped one is hung on his arm, while the crocodile which is looking at the mirror is with the dark purple one on his arm (Figure 3).

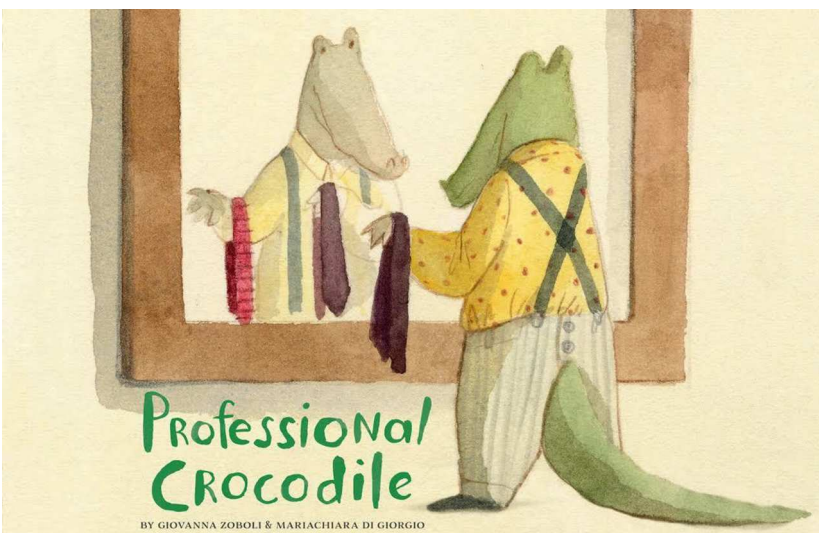

Figure 3. Front cover in Professional Crocodile.

The positions of the dark purple ties are against the logic. The red and dark purple ties in the mirror should be switched, or the crocodile outside of mirror should hold the red striped tie, if my reading is correct.

What I am observing here is an alienation that relates not to the animal versus the human, or the dash between them. Instead, Mr. Crocodile fails to coincide with himself. As already introduced, and to be explored later, not only does getting ready for work in a suit and tie contradict the nature of the work that is to be performed, but the act of seeing oneself also involves division. If self-reflection is read as the mark of the animal-man, that which differentiates him from the birds outside, then it also differentiates him from himself. Just as we read in the sequence of frames that provides continuity to the self by creating a division within it, we also recognise a split here that cannot be confined solely to the structure of repetition. And between the two Mr. Crocodiles, there is the mirror, which I now interpret as the dash that acts as a third, neither animal nor man, self nor other, but necessary for their division and their connection. In one sense, the mirror – or the crocodile standing in front of it – is what enables a reading of the ironic world in which he lives.

4. Going to work and being at work

There are other examples of animal-man/man-animal in the world where Mr. Crocodile lives (see Figure 4). If I regard the darkest colour as the exterior part of a train, I could notice, again, that the perspective is not from Mr. Crocodile (Figure 4). The perspective is not situated inside the train. From the exterior part of the train, different creatures can be observed. There are people with different appearances with different facial expressions. Some of them, I cannot see their faces (Figure 4). In keeping with the reading offered above, there is a move to locate the human, and the man-animal/animal-man inside.

In terms of the animal-man/animal-man in the train frame, I differentiate Mr. Crocodile, a giraffe with red sunglasses, and a monkey with his notepad.

Figure 4. Mr. Crocodile in the subway.

They are all added with different accessories and clothes. They all must head to somewhere as they are in the train. The idea of destination in the case of Mr. Crocodile is what subverts and refines notions of professionalism. What does it mean, then, that we do not know the destination of the giraffe? Does it necessarily end in a comparable place to Mr. Crocodile? One difficulty here is that the division that might be read in the variety of clothes and the possibility of difference of direction or purpose of going somewhere is undercut by the singularity of the frame.

As Mr. Crocodile arrives at the place where he works, he passes several monkeys. He does not salute any of them. One of the monkeys is holding a phone, and another is reading a book. Not all the monkeys are occupied like these two, but none of them salute Mr. Crocodile. This spectacle is comparable with some other scenes where Mr Crocodile had raised his hand (is it a *hand*?) to greet a merchant at a store and giving a flower bouquet to the staff at the gate when he was entering his workplace. Without talking to his colleagues (there is no speech in this world), Mr. Crocodile enters the locker room. He takes off his coat and wraps a towel around his body. He does a warm-up exercise. When Mr. Crocodile enters the door from the locker room, it is followed by another room where he could display his own body through the glass wall.

There is a door which leads to another room. Is he finally getting into his office room (is it an *office room*?). The room he enters is as follows the corresponding frame: (see Figure 5). The corresponding frame shows Mr. Crocodile *being* a professional crocodile. There is here, one might say, a simple division in *being*, therefore, with Mr. Crocodile split from what he has been from the first page. In one sense, it shows the impossibility of a true professionalism of *nature*. One can never act natural; naturalness can neither be work, nor worked at. *Professional Crocodile*, read on these terms, is concerned with the necessary excess to nature, and the sense in which this can register its other: professionalism; labour; the frame; the human. But such distinctions, as we shall read, are even less secure as they might appear here.

Figure 5. Two people from the train and Mr. Crocodile at his workplace.

There are two witnesses on the other side of glass wall. Because of their location and the material in front of them, neither can touch Mr. Crocodile. What they can do is watch a crocodile from the other side of its cage. These two witnesses were also in the train (see and compare Figure 4 and 5). In the train, these three were all at the same place. There was no glass wall, nothing was blocking any creatures when they were in the train, other than the equalising and othering frame of the train itself. However, the situation is no longer the same when Mr. Crocodile becomes, as we now might tentatively suggest, *professional*. Due to the title and the blurb (or the explanation from the publisher), he is not only working but also being *professional as a crocodile*. Being professional is to be displayed, enclosed, and distinguished from the human beings in that sense.

There was no human inside the fences or glass wall when Mr. Crocodile was coming to his workplace. It seems that the human beings such as a child and a guardian who are looking at Mr. Crocodile will not be exhibited to the others. This crocodile in *Professional Crocodile* cannot be a human since he is professional. As long as he is being professional, it will be a crocodile who will be distinguished from human beings and other animals when it is time to be professional. However, there is a challenge here: the professionalism, which we have seen, relies on factors such as clothing, preparation, and a caring attitude toward the work, even when one is not directly involved in it. The Professional Crocodile, therefore, can be analysed as a reading of labour and employment, of the way work extends beyond its borders, the sense in which professionalism intrudes into the life of home, into the commute, into the clothed identity that opposes, yet secures through its very supplementation, the identity of the Mr. Crocodile who is professional. In other words, if this Professional Crocodile is the crocodile that goes under the glass, not Mr. Crocodile on his commute who has yet to remove his clothes, professionalism also emerges precisely through the construction of the animal-man/the man-animal, encompassing everything that exists beyond *the scene of professional activity*.

This professionalism would be questioned in terms of intention[15]: is he willing to do this job, or was he forced to do it? If neither of these is the case, then is it the system (or the society) that made him do such a job and be professional? Whatever the answer may be, the result of being professional shows that Mr. Crocodile needs to be this way (Figure 5). His professionalism at the end of the story is revealed as he is naked and working with his four feet (or two hands and two feet? I am not sure). I cannot see his face, and his emotions remain unknown because I am merely a spectator, just like the child and grandmother on the other side of the glass wall, watching him working. It has been stated by the publisher that 'he loves his job', but does he really? Perhaps he does, but I still cannot hear, see, or feel any voice, thoughts, or emotions from him.

I would like to draw on a quote from picture book critic Karen Coats to read out this last illustration in *Professional Crocodile*: 'Closure is only ever pre-closure, and any other stance taken in fiction is an imposition of stability and orderliness that doesn't accord with the ebb and flow of daily experience'.[16] If his display at the end is 'only ever pre-closure', which is 'an imposition of stability' and 'orderliness', then is this other to what has gone before, the 'ebb and flow of daily experience'? In other words, and in agreement with Coats, the final scene, the revelation of the joke, does not bring anything to a close, but this, I would argue, is because it is caught up in a repetition effect. Professionalism, as I have been arguing, is non-locatable. Or, at least, it does not wholly reside in the scene of revelation. Thus, for example, the last scene reminds me of the front cover, as read above, where the crocodile and another crocodile are facing each other in the between of the mirror. As long as he is professional, Mr. Crocodile will inevitably repeat the ironic alienation of the mirror scene, with closure caught up in the divisions and repetitions to be read across the book: closure as pre-closure.

Here, we might return to the reading of sequence above, where Mr. Crocodile was understood to be a continuous identity through being repeated, and thus split, across individual frames. As the series of individual frames persists throughout the entire narrative, the framed sequence constructs the fragmented identity of Mr. Crocodile: Mr. Crocodile (staying at home, picking the tie for himself, taking the train) and the Professional Crocodile (staying in the glass cage without wearing any clothes, he is stared at by humans). On the other hand, however, this iteration represents the continuity of Professional Crocodile, an identity shaped by the antagonisms of animal-man and man-animal: *Professional-Crocodile*.

5. Conclusion: uncover the crocodile

In conclusion, I would like to turn again to *The Open: Man and Animal* and think a little more about being, looking and the gaze:

> Insofar as the animal knows neither beings nor nonbeings, neither open nor closed, it is outside of being; it is outside in an exteriority more external than any open, and inside in an intimacy more internal than any closedness. To let the animal be would then mean: to let it be *outside of being*. The zone of nonknowledge – or of a-knowledge – that is at issue here is beyond both knowing and not knowing, beyond both disconcealing and concealing, beyond both being and the nothing. But what is thus left to be outside of being is not thereby negated or taken away; it is not, for this reason, inexistent. It is an existing, real thing that has gone beyond the difference between being and beings.[17]

The knowledge of 'the animal' is known to the perspective on 'the animal'. After reading this text from Agamben, what 'the animal' 'knows' is also

known to me. Therefore, me, the perspective on the statement above, and someone who might read this text all know that 'the animal knows neither beings nor nonbeings, neither open nor closed, it is outside of being'. The knowledge of 'the animal' and its position are claimed together within the text. It seems that 'being' has 'outside', and 'the animal' is 'outside of being'. However, it does not mean that 'the animal' is alienated from the inside. '[T]he animal' is not *in*side of 'being', but there is 'outside' and 'inside' for 'the animal'. '[O]pen' and 'closedness' affect the location of 'the animal' and they are the reason why 'the animal' is not located at a single place. It is not 'the animal' which decides its location; 'the animal' has already been decided to be there 'outside of being' and 'inside in intimacy more internal than any closedness'.

An idea of 'external' is claimed with 'open', and an idea of 'internal' is claimed with 'closedness'. Since it is stated as 'any open', there are different kinds of open and closedness. No matter what kind of open/closedness it is, 'the animal' is positioned in the certain places of 'open' and 'closedness'. In the case of 'an exteriority', something could be positioned 'more external' than where 'an exteriority' is. In the case of 'an intimacy', something could be positioned 'more internal' than where 'an intimacy' is. '[T]he animal' exceeds the boundary of 'an exteriority' and 'an intimacy'. '[T]he animal' has been positioned somewhere particular around 'any open' and 'any closedness'. In other words, 'the animal' cannot be positioned anywhere when it is near 'any open' and 'any closedness'.

'[T]he animal' is not free because it is something to be 'let'. In other words, 'the animal' needs to be 'let' by what is other than 'the animal' itself. In addition, 'let[ting]' 'the animal' has a 'mean[ing]'. 'To let the animal' is not simply 'let[ting]' 'the animal. When it is 'let' by the other, its presence is '*outside of being*'. There, 'the animal' is neither a '*being*' nor inside of '*being*'. '[T]he animal' is again '*outside of being*' when it is 'let' by the other.

There are two different 'zone[s]': one of 'nonknowledge' and another of 'a-knowledge'. These 'zone[s]' are related to the matter of 'knowing', 'concealing', and 'being'. I read that 'knowing and not knowing', 'disconcealing and concealing' and 'being and the nothing' are the groups of contrasting concepts. For Agamben, '[t]he zone of nonknowledge – or of a-knowledge' is related to these three groups, 'knowing and not knowing', 'disconcealing and concealing', and 'being and the nothing', but it is not exactly 'knowing and not knowing', 'disconcealing and concealing', and 'being and the nothing' as it is all 'beyond' them.

Then, something is to *be* (my emphasis) 'outside of being'. Something has been 'left to be' there, 'outside of being'. '[W]hat is thus left to be outside' did not go there by itself, since it is 'thus left to be' there. Since 'it is not […] inexistent', I regard that 'it' might be existent 'outside of being'. As I have suspected in the previous sentence, '[i]t' can then be claimed as 'an existing'.

'It' is not only 'inexistent' but also continuously 'existing' particularly at the 'outside of being'. 'It' is also a 'real thing', and the definition of 'real thing' within the text is that it 'has gone beyond the difference between being and beings'. The perspective on the statement above sees that 'being' and 'beings' are different from each other. They are different not only because of their numbers but also because of 'the difference'. Due to 'the difference', there might be the betweenness between 'being' and 'beings'.

I read something of the irony of animal being to be engaged through an image from Professional Crocodile we have not yet discussed (see Figure 6). There, Mr. Crocodile is not in his workplace. The place where he is swimming is not his house. It seems the environment is somewhere other than what I have seen from *Professional Crocodile*. He does not wear anything, not a tie, suspenders, nor a hat. He is swimming, and I do not see any wall and spectators around him (Figure 6). Is this, then, something other than being professional? Is this, in other words, simply *the animal*? The structure of the picture book in some way supports such a notion. In one sense, this is a *hidden* image: That is because the English translated version has two different front pages, the first is the mirror-looking illustration which covers the book with paper, and the following image will be shown when the mirror-looking one is uncovered (Figure 6). These images cannot be seen together, therefore (unless one removes the jacket cover). Removed from the play of animal-man and man-animal, that is, from the sequences of the book – with its various repetitions and differences – might we read the swimming crocodile as independent, as the animal without audience, as overcoming the dash that splits identity, and in a way that means the genuinely animal cannot be encountered?

Figure 6. When the front cover is uncovered: The hidden image.

Clearly, there is a problem with such a reading. We might begin, for example, with notions of audience and framing. There is no frame that would suggest a glass wall and no spectators, yet this is still a perspective *on* the crocodile. We cannot see what the crocodile is seeing, and the absence of spectators does not entail an absence of audience, where audience, in terms of the narrating third, is constituted precisely as absence. To rephrase: the absence of an audience in the hidden image does not entirely eliminate the chance of it being observed (while the absence of the black framing around the glass aquarium does not negate the idea of framing: the swimming crocodile is framed by the page). Here, we can discern aspects of the issue of knowledge and framing as I analyse the quotation from Agamben above, particularly regarding Sue Walsh's introduction of the question concerning the impossibility of the natural in literature.

Next, we may explore the interplay of inside and outside, which we have observed throughout the text: animality as an outsideness, the ironic idea that human spectators remain outside the glass frame, the exteriority of the dream, and the exteriority inherent in the constitutive perspectives on the man-animal and animal-man throughout the entire sequence of the text. There is an outside to the text, as it were. Through the 'hidden' image, *inside*, and thus covered over, by the dust jacket, the swimming crocodile is, perhaps, *outside* the narrative, set apart from the preparation and performance that constitute animal professionalism. The outside is the inside.[18] And it follows from this that the independence of the crocodile can be read to be compromised through its very success: in requiring what I have termed the play of inside and outside, the crocodile's separateness is caught up in an opposition through which both professionalism and animality are negotiated.

Finally – but this is pre-closure only – the double cover can be read to repeat one half of it: the mirror image of the two crocodiles. One attempt at closure may claim that one is professional (looking in the mirror) and one is not (swimming), and thus we have something different from the impossible split in professionalism seen within the rest of the book, where a crocodile without clothes is as professional as one who is dressing. But this is pre-closure, I would argue, because it opens a further question: is the one in the water 'professional' when there is nothing around him except for the illustration? Is professionalism an excess? And, if so, how are we to confirm that there is indeed nothing around this crocodile other than illustration? How to foreclose a notion of audience, or, indeed, the rest of the text? How to secure the animal against its other without including that other?

Notes

1. For more research on animals or human/animal hybrids in children's literature, see, for instance, Matthew Cole and Kate Stewart, *Our Children and*

Other Animals: The Cultural Construction of Human-Animal Relations in Childhood (London: Routledge, 2014); Margaret Blount, *Animal Land: The Creatures of Children's Fiction* (New York: William Morrow, 1975); Zoe Jaques, *Children's Literature and the Posthuman: Animal, Environment, Cyborgs* (New York: Routledge, 2015); Chengcheng You, 'The Necessity of an Anthropomorphic Approach to Children's Literature', *Children's Literature in Education*, 52.2 (2020), pp. 183–99.

2. Carolyn Burke and Joby Copenhaver, 'Animals as People in Children's Literature', *Language Arts*, 81.3 (2004), pp. 205–13 (p. 205).
3. Anthropomorphism in children's picture books has been the subject of study in many cases. There is a research, for instance, on picture books in the Netherlands to examine how animals can be assigned different roles in the stories. This study focuses on analysing several books from specific age groups and years in the Netherlands to present data analysis. In contrast, my research concentrates on a single case from children's literature and involves a sustained close reading of perspective. For further reading: M. J. D. Hooykaas, M. G. Holierhoek, J. S. Westerveld, M. Schilthuizen, and I. Smeets, 'Animal Biodiversity and Specificity in Children's Picture Books', *Public Understanding of Science*, 31.5 (2019), pp. 671–88 (p. 674).
4. Sue Walsh, 'The Recuperated Materiality of Disability and Animal Studies', in K. Lesnik-Oberstein (ed.), *Rethinking Disability Theory and Practice: Challenging Essentialism* (Houndmills, Basingstoke and New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015), pp. 20–36 (p. 26).
5. Helen Adhuze, 'The Face and Phases of Anthropomorphism in Children's Literature', *Tasambo Journal of Language Literature and Culture*, 1.1 (2022), pp. 47–55 (p. 47).
6. See for further examples on corresponding research: Sue Walsh, 'Nature Faking and the Problem of the "Real"', *Interdisciplinary Studies in Literature and Environment*, 22.1 (2015), pp. 132–52, Domenica B., Pietro Perconti and Allessio Plebe, 'Anti-Anthropomorphism and Its Limits', *Frontiers in Psychology*, 9 (2018); Mattew Wills, 'Nature Fakers and Real Naturalists', *JSTOR Daily* (2023), https://daily.jstor.org/nature-fakers-and-real-naturalists/ [Date accessed: 24 October 2024].
7. Giovanna Zoboli and Mariachiara Di Giorgio, *Professional Crocodile* (San Fransico: Chronicle Books, 2017).
8. Its Italian title is *Professione Coccodrillo*; it was translated into French, English, Chinese, Korean, Spanish, German, Dutch, and Russian. For the specific details about this book from the publisher, see more details on: https://www.topipittori.it/en/catalogo/professional-crocodile [Date accessed: 5 March 2024]
9. As a Korean academic, I could have chosen a Korean translated book. However, the publisher provides Italian and English introductory notes of this book on their website. In terms of my personal ability to understand foreign languages, I decided to read this book in its English translation in this paper.
10. On the website of Topipittori, it comments about the book that 'Mr. Crocodile loves his job. Every morning he gets up with an alarm. He brushes his teeth. He chooses the right tie to match his outfit, eats a quick slice of toast, and heads off to work on a crowded train. But what exactly is his job? The answer may surprise you! Readers will want to pore over this witty, wordless book again and again,

finding new details and fresh stories with every reading'. See: https://www.topipittori.it/en/catalogo/professional-crocodile [Date accessed: 1 February 2024].

11. In this paper, I read an English translated book published in 2004. It was originally published in Italian in 2002 under the title, *L'aperto: L'uomo e L'animale*.
12. Agamben's differentiation between man and animal comes from 'language'. For more details on their categorisation and differentiation, see 'Anthropological Machine', in *The Open: Man and Animal*, trans. Kevin Attel and ed. Werner Hamacher (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2004), pp. 33–8 (p. 36).
13. Ibid., p. 36.
14. Ibid., p. 36.
15. The word 'intention' in this article refers to Flusser. 'For "intention" needs to be defined, and because it is an unstable concept that involves issues of subjectivity and of freedom, it will surely get us into difficulties'. Vilém Flusser, 'Gesture and Affect: The Practice of a Phenomenology of Gestures', in *Gestures*, trans. Nancy Ann Roth (Minnesota: University of Minnesota Press, 2014), pp. 1–9 (p. 1).
16. Karen Coats, 'The End?: Approaches to Closure in Early Readers', in *The Early Reader in Children's Literature and Culture: Theorizing Books for Beginning Readers*, ed. Jennifer M. Miskec and Annette Wannamaker (New York: Routledge, 2016), pp. 57–70 (p. 69).
17. Giorgio Agamben, *The Open: Man and Animal*, trans. Kevin Attel and ed. Werner Hamacher, (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2004) pp. 91–2.
18. I am thinking here of Jacques Derrida's 'Fors: les mots angle´s de Nicolas Abraham et Maria Torok', in *Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok, Cryptonymie: Le Verbier de l'homme Aux Loups* (Paris: Flammarion, 1976), pp. 7–73. Mr Crocodile as a kind of cryptic animal, inside as far as he is outside.

Disclosure statement

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